

Part I
Realism



Modern political philosophy begins in Europe in the seventeenth century when Hobbes attempts to find a solution to the problem his contemporaries have in living together without assuming either a divinely ordained and enforced order, or a naturally implanted, invariable, and irresistibly powerful human impulse toward one particular form of cooperative action. Any entity that modern political agents would recognise as a human being in the full sense has grown up as a member of a human group, that is, among other humans who interact with each other in a certain way, minimally in what is called a “nuclear family” and most likely in a family embedded in a variety of larger kinship groups, loose networks of friends and neighbours, and perhaps more formal political structures. Although, however, it seems a natural and not an artificial fact about humans as we know them—to the extent to which one can make this distinction at all—that we are in this sense social and not solitary creatures, it is also the case that in modern societies human interaction is not something that can ever be taken for granted; it is always potentially disrupted, unstable, and conflict-ridden. The members of a human group are not parts of a single organism, like the hands or feet of an animal, who have no will of their own, nor are we like bees, ants, or even herd animals whose strong natural instincts can be counted on, at least in some areas, to be powerful enough to assure more or less harmonious coordination. Rather, humans, even in the most repressive societies we know, grow up to be individuated creatures who are separate centres for the formation, evaluation, and revision of beliefs, attitudes, values, and desires, and for the initiation of action that puts these beliefs and desires into effect. So coordination of action in

our societies, either of a negative kind (that I don't act so as to thwart your plans) or of a positive kind (that I act so as to maximise the attainment of some goal that can be reached only by joint effort) is always a social achievement, and it is something attained and preserved, and generally achieved only at a certain price. People are very quick to observe that there is a wide variety of different ways in which collective action can be organised, and, given that different forms of collective action are also differentially beneficial, this in itself may well motivate some to try to change existing patterns.

What I wish to call "the realist approach to political philosophy" develops this basically Hobbesian insight. It is centred on the study of historically instantiated forms of collective human action with special attention to the variety of ways in which people can structure and organise their action so as to limit and control forms of disorder that they might find excessive or intolerable for other reasons. This is a historically specific study if only because the concepts of "order" and "intolerable disorder" are themselves variable magnitudes. That is, people's general level of tolerance of unregimented, unpredictable, or random action, and the extent to which specific kinds of lack of order particularly trouble them, vary considerably from one time and one society to another. Thus few modern Western European populations would tolerate the anarchic freedom to own private firearms that is held to be a positive constituent of the good life in the United States, or the freedom from a nationally organized form of health insurance; and from the twelfth to the seventeenth century a society *not* based on religious uniformity was almost unthinkable. One person's disorder is sometimes another's freedom, and so much conceptual con-

fusion reigns in this area that even Baghdad in 2003 could be described with a straight face by U.S. Secretary of Defense Donald Rumsfeld as an instance of “untidy freedom.” The variation in the perception of what counts as “order” or “freedom” is often itself a source of tension between individuals and groups. One of two neighbouring countries can accept levels of petty border raiding as a natural concomitant of social life, while the other sees, or pretends to see, in it a *casus belli*.

The way to develop the realistic spirit of Hobbes in the contemporary world, I wish to suggest, is not by assuming that one needs an antecedent ontological specification of a distinct domain called “politics,” but by considering a set of questions. When we speak of politics, we are generally thinking of possible answers to one or another, or several, of three kinds of question. For ease of reference I will call these the questions of Lenin, of Nietzsche, and of Max Weber. These questions will be rather loosely specified, and conjoining them means lumping together enquiries that actually differ in content and meaning, depending on the time at which they are posed, who is asking the question with what intention, who is being interrogated, and the purpose of the interrogation, but, then, that is precisely part of the point I wish to make.

Who Whom?

Lenin defines politics with characteristic clarity and pithiness when he says that it is concerned with the question that keeps recurring in our political life: “Who whom?” (кто кого) What this means in the first instance is that the imper-

sonalised statements one might be inclined to make about human societies generally require, if they are to be politically informative, elaboration into statements about particular concrete people doing things to other people. The sign in the Underground that reads, "Non-payment of fare will be punished" means that a policeman may arrest and fine you, if you fail to buy a ticket; "Unemployment has risen by x percent" means that certain people who have control of particular economic organisations have done something concrete, terminated the employment, of certain other people.

To say that the question "Who whom?" "keeps recurring" does not, of course, mean that for literally every single human society that has existed or will exist this is a question that "necessarily" arises in every context. The extent to which it does arise, the forms in which it arises, and the importance of the question will vary historically. Perhaps there are contexts and societies in which this question is irrelevant, but for most of the societies with which we have direct dealings, and the ones to which we have relatively straightforward cognitive access, this is a question that arises again and again, and for what we can see are good reasons. One strand of "liberalism," represented, for instance, in the early writings of Humboldt,¹¹ is devoted to trying to imagine a structure of free political institutions, relative to which this question would be so unimportant that it would become irrelevant to ask who were the rulers and who were the ruled. The centrepiece of the argument was the idea of a strict limitation of government. *If* government was sufficiently limited, the thought ran, it would not matter who was in a position to operate the state apparatus, and who was subject to it. Utopian speculation, of course, is free and in some senses highly

desirable, but if this liberal suggestion was intended to imply that such a free form of political organisation was actually *realisable* under nineteenth-, twentieth-, or twenty-first-century economic conditions, that was certainly an illusion.

Obviously, how specific the answer to the question “Who whom?” needs to be will depend on the time and place, and the purpose of the question. In some relatively simple cases and for some purposes the answer to the question might be the name of particular persons—Brian is Paul’s line manager, so “Brian” is the “who” and Paul the “whom”—but in most cases in complex societies the answer will be the naming of an office, position, or institution. It is “a policeman”—whichever individual member of the police force is assigned that role—who arrests me for nonpayment of fare. That he happens to be PC John Jones is not relevant. How important it is to specify the individuals concerned, for instance designating them by their proper names, rather than simply referring to the roles or positions involved, will depend on the problem at issue and the kind of society in question. An important part of answering the question will be to discover what *kind* of answer is required in the specific circumstances, which is a question of proper categorisation.

Although Lenin’s formula is basically correct, it is perhaps too dense and needs to be developed or extended: actually, I would argue, it needs to be extended twice. First of all, the formula should read not merely “Who whom?” but, rather, “Who <does> what to whom for whose benefit?” with four distinct variables to be filled in, i.e., (1) Who?, (2) What?, (3) To whom?, (4) For whose benefit? To think politically is to think about agency, power, and interests, and the relations among these. Who—which individuals or the bearers

of which offices, positions, or roles—has control of employment in the society, and who have lost their jobs? Will those who have lost their jobs have access to alternative modes of subsistence or not? Who will provide those alternatives, and what exactly will they be (provision of cash payments, vouchers, or jobs in the public sector by the government, or of shelter and food by charities)? Are the unemployed organised, and capable of collective action, or are they disorganised and inert, and if they are organised, what form does this organisation take? What concretely has one party done to the other: How exactly will the policeman punish me? Will he give me a warning, impose a fine, hit me with his truncheon, or take me to jail? Will he also expect a bribe? Finally, who benefits and who does not from the transaction in question? Who derives distinct positive benefits from any individual action or type of action in a given society will often be an extremely complex question.

The second extension of Lenin's formula is connected with another important feature of our social life. We relate to other people not merely in terms of what they have done to us or are doing to us, but also with regard to what they will or *could* do to us. If I have certain effective powers, these may have a sufficiently intimidating effect on others that I get my way without ever needing actually to exercise these powers. So if we wish to understand how human action in a certain society comes to be coordinated, how some individuals or groups bring it about that others embark on certain courses of action or refrain from embarking on others, one of the things we will need to take into account is not just who actually does what to whom, but also who has what powers, i.e., who *could* do what to whom for whose benefit.

One must also take account not only of what powers an individual or group actually has, but also of how those powers are perceived, or not perceived, and what powers agents are, rightly or wrongly, *thought* to have by others (and by themselves). To think one has a power that one does not can give an agent self-confidence, which may be self-reinforcing (but also may not, depending on circumstances). Given the role that intimidation can play, one important “power” that an agent, whether an individual or a society, can have is the ability to control how others perceive its powers or what they *imagine* these powers to be.

In this account “power” is to be construed as connected with general concepts like “ability to do” (such as that I have the power of speech or of locomotion), rather than as designating exclusively a form of coercion (such as “the hostages remained in the power of the gang until they were freed by the police”) or domination (“the Athenians reasserted their power over the island of Chios”). It is probably a mistake to treat “power” as if it referred to a single, uniform substance or relation wherever it was found. It makes more sense to distinguish a variety of qualitatively distinct kinds of powers. There are strictly coercive powers you may have by virtue of being physically stronger than me, persuasive powers by virtue of being convinced of the moral rightness of your case and having special training or a natural talent for speaking; you may be more powerful than I am by virtue of being a charismatic figure who is able to attract enthusiastic, voluntary support from others, or by virtue of being able to see and exploit a strategic, rhetorical, or diplomatic weakness in my position. Contemporary political scientists often contrast “hard” and “soft” power, and there is nothing wrong

with this contrast provided one takes it as no more than a first, preliminary account of the different types and forms of power that one can discover in a given society. How many types one would have to distinguish would depend on the context of the enquiry.¹²

If one takes this extended Leninist model as the matrix for political philosophy, certain consequences would seem to follow. The first is that it would be a mistake to believe that one could come to any substantive understanding of politics by discussing abstractly the good, the right, the true, or the rational in complete abstraction from the way in which these items figure in the more motivationally active parts of the human psyche, and particularly in abstraction from the way in which they impinge, even if indirectly, on human action. This, in turn, requires an understanding of the existing social and political institutions. In politics “It would be good if . . . (e.g., the tsar were overthrown)” means someone has decided that it would be desirable or advisable if this were to take place, or at any rate has entertained the possibility that this might be done. “Who is that?” is always a pertinent question. It also means that someone is in principle willing to try to implement “the good” that has been determined, even if the form that attempt at implementation takes is a series of weak and ineffectual actions that amount to no more than some seditious conversations, or committing to memory a subversive poem.¹³ This in no way implies that there is no such thing as truth. Lenin famously claimed that Marx’s theory was powerful *because* it was true, and not the other way around.¹⁴ Still, neither the good nor the true is self-realising, so it is not generally a sufficient explanation of

why people believe that X that X is true or of why people do Y that Y is “good.”

There is one further element to be found in Lenin’s writings that is of special importance for political theory: his discussion of the principle of partisanship.¹⁵ That is his claim that there are only two philosophical ways of looking at the world: materialism and idealism. These are incompatible global theories that constitute the respective correctly understood worldviews of the bourgeoisie and the proletariat, and they are as irreconcilably at war with each other as are their respective hosts. *Every* theory to some extent takes a position in this war; every theory is “partisan.” Therefore, intellectual honesty requires that one reflect on the contribution one’s theory makes to the class struggle, and acknowledge it openly. One does not have to accept the specific claim that there are two, and only two, mutually exclusive worldviews to one of which any theory must commit itself, to accept the general claim that entertaining, developing, and propounding a theory are actions, and as such they represent ways of taking a position in the world. This means that any kind of comprehensive understanding of politics will also have to treat the politics of theorisation, including the politics of whatever theory is itself at the given time being presented for scrutiny as a candidate for acceptance. One need not assume that “honesty” requires one specifically to elaborate and call attention to the partisan commitments of one’s theory in every possible context, because contexts and the legitimate questions to which they give rise differ, and there is nothing in principle wrong with accepting a certain amount of intellectual division of labour.

Still, the general point that a political theory is, among other things, potentially a partisan intervention is well-taken, so questions about the actual political implications of a theory cannot be excluded as in principle irrelevant.

Priorities, Preferences, Timing

That, then, is the first and by far most important of the three questions the conjunction of which in some sense—namely, for the realist view with which I am concerned—maps out the realm of politics. The second question is, by contrast, one that represents not a new line of thought, but something more like an addendum to the first. The best way to think about how the second question arises is to think about Nietzsche's insistence on the finitude of human existence and on the fact that the structure of human valuation is always differential. The model for most politics, according to Nietzsche, should not be that of an irresistible *ἐρως* that draws individuals on, so that they follow looking neither to the right nor to the left. To the extent to which the pull that moves me really is irresistible, like an invincibly strong addiction, then the normal procedures of evaluation, deliberation, choice, decision, etc., that constitute the substance of our political life are not operating. The same is true of overwhelming aversion. The person being tortured who simply wants it to STOP (PERIOD) is also not a good model for an agent acting politically. Politics as we know it is a matter of differential choice: opting for A *rather than* B.¹⁶ Thus politics is not about doing what is good or rational or beneficial *simpliciter*—it is not even obvious that that is an internally coherent thought at all—but about the pursuit of what is good

in a particular concrete case by agents with limited powers and resources, where choice of one thing to pursue means failure to choose and pursue another.

I would like to group here a number of phenomena having to do with order, sequence, priority, and the temporality or historicity of collective action. To propose that we do X is always to propose that we do X rather than any other possible action, or at any rate that we do X before we do something else. In many cases, the specific order in which one makes decisions is of crucial importance for the actual medium-term result. In an ideal discussion (e.g., of the kind envisaged by Habermas) in which one has, as we say, “all the time in the world,” it might not make much difference which topic is discussed first because we will eventually make it our task to get to everything, and can revisit topics without restriction in the light of changes in our views. Whether or not that is the case in idealised academic discussion is not a matter I wish to discuss now, but however that might be, in countless cases of political action what comes first is of great importance for obvious reasons. Once I have done something, I have changed the situation, sometimes for good. As the Bush administration in the United States has perhaps learned, once you destroy something like the Iraqi polity, the pieces cannot necessarily be reassembled.

A related aspect of politics is the importance of timing in political action. Successful action, particularly large-scale action of a drastic kind, often depends on making a delicate judgment about what is realistically possible at what point in time, on identifying the *καιρός*—the moment that must be seized now because it will never recur—seeing when the time is ripe for action and grasping opportunities

that will not present themselves again. An ability to pick the crucial moment when action can be successful is an important constituent of one of the skills a good politician exhibits.¹⁷

All three of the patrons I have named, Lenin, Nietzsche, and Weber, emphasise the importance of this feature. Lenin had no *theory* of this, and in fact it seems obvious that there are very narrow limits to how far one could have a general theory of this kind of specific skill, since by its very nature it is the exercising of highly particularised judgment on what might be a nonrecurrent situation, but the emphasis one finds in his speeches and writing on performing potentially far-reaching political action only at a specified “right” moment, neither too early nor too late, gives evidence that he was aware of the importance of this skill.

One might imagine that this category would be especially important for political actors who had a specific philosophy of history, like that of Marxism which considers history to be a generally progressive phenomenon. Thus Social Democrats at the beginning of the twentieth century discussed endlessly when the time would be ripe for revolutionary action, i.e., when the economic situation would be sufficiently propitious, the proletariat would be sufficiently “mature,” and the party would be psychologically, socially, and politically prepared to act, and eventually to take power. However, it is incorrect to think that this is a specific concern of views that emphasise the progressive nature of history. Marxists, to be sure, worried about whether society was sufficiently developed, but this development was generally considered to be a cumulative and, for all practical purposes, irreversible process, so if you failed this time, that was disappoint-

ing, and wasteful, but, on the mainstream view, it was not necessarily tragic, because history was on your side and the conditions for better luck the next time were reliably there. Recognising the importance of choosing the propitious moment might also be characteristic of conceptions completely different from those mentioned above. Skill in timing political action might be thought to be particularly important precisely if I thought of the political world as providing opportunities that would not present themselves again, that is, if I had to discriminate and act on specific features of the situation that could *not* be assumed to be permanent or to recur in an appropriate form. For instance, when a group of U.S. politicians decided that they would try to remove Iraq as an independent agent in world affairs, either by installing there a government that would be reliably subservient to U.S. geopolitical interests, or by destroying the country completely as a political subject capable of making any effective decisions in international affairs at all, it was likely to have been clear to them from the start that they would have to find or create an opportunity for toppling the Ba'athist regime. The attack on the Pentagon and the World Trade Center in 2001 provided a suitable window of opportunity by generating an enormous amount of indiscriminating vengeful energy that could, with sufficient manipulation, be redirected against Iraq, but it was clear that that window would not stay open indefinitely because the desire for revenge in most cases eventually fades away. In a way Lenin's emphasis on timing is a departure from the main line of Marxist theorising, which by the start of the twentieth century had become slightly academic in the pejorative sense of the term. Lenin shifted the focus back from a very general, specula-

tive theory of history to the realities of political practice in particular situations.

Legitimacy

The third question I wish to raise is one with a long history, but in its modern form it is most clearly articulated by Max Weber. Sometimes human beings feel themselves forced to act by overwhelming pressures in their environment, and sometimes we simply give ourselves over to routines and established habits of action. When the pressure to act, however, is relaxed slightly and our routines are interrupted, we are also capable of asking ourselves *why* we should act in one way rather than another, that is, we look for reasons for action and exchange these with one another. Weber speaks of people who are trying to find reasons for action as engaged in looking for “legitimation” of that action. He thought that politics was generally about collective forms of *legitimizing* violence, and he had a refreshingly catholic, and normatively undemanding, notion of what “legitimation” was to be taken to be. Thus Weber was even willing to speak of what he called “legitimation via tradition,” which was a situation in which one can just barely distinguish there *being* any legitimation of some form of violent behaviour as opposed to its merely being the case that violence of that sort took place “habitually.” Weber’s idea, of course, was not that politics was in every specific instance about giving or objecting to a particular legitimising argument for a particular act of violence, but, rather, that there was a generalised human order that claimed and had some kind of legitimacy, and part of that legitimacy was, in one or another of a variety of complex

and indirect ways, transmitted down to the acts of violence that were perpetrated as a normal part of social interaction. It seems reasonable to widen the focus slightly. Perhaps, as Weber thought, the characteristic of modern states is that they have control over the threat to use certain kinds of concentrated force as their *ultima ratio*, but not all politics is, in its immediate phenomenal reality, about the control of violence. There are, after all, as Weber knew very well, other ways of coordinating human action apart from the use of force. So a more realistic understanding of what is at issue in politics in a wider variety of circumstances would connect it with attempts to provide legitimacy not simply for acts of violence, but for any kinds of collective action, such as deciding voluntarily to build a new road or change to a new unit of measurement (as was done during the French Revolution), or for that matter for any arrangements that could be seen as capable of being changed, controlled, modified, or influenced by human action. This will include institutions, patterns of distribution of access to resources, and other similar things.

The legitimacy mechanisms available in a given society change from one historical period to another, as do the total set of beliefs held by agents, the mechanisms for changing beliefs, or generating new ones (newspapers, universities, etc.), and the forms of widely distributed, socially rooted, moral conceptions. These are all important parts of what makes a given society the society it is. When the pope crowned Charlemagne emperor in AD 800, this legitimizing act had very significant political consequences; nothing comparable would have been possible in AD 80, or in 2008. Partly the reason for this is that there is no emperor in 2008,

but partly it is that in AD 80 the very idea of the man called “the pope” dispensing political legitimation would not have made much sense to anyone then alive. If one wants to attain a moderately realistic understanding of why a society behaves politically in a certain way, one will have to take account of the specific way the existing forms of legitimation work. There is nothing “realistic” about closing one’s eyes to the fact that such warrants for action exist and are taken seriously. This does *not*, of course, mean that they constitute a closed system at any given time, or that everyone shares the same legitimatory beliefs at any given time in any given society—the plebs and the patricians may well continue to differ about that—or that the ability or inability of a political agent to provide a legitimation for a particular policy is the most important fact, or even an important fact, about that policy. The beliefs that lie at the base of forms of legitimation are often as confused, potentially contradictory, incomplete, and pliable as anything else, and they can in principle be manipulated, although in most cases not *ad libitum*. Although they are not mere “reflections” of something else—certainly not *mere* “superstructural reflections of the economic base,” as held, for instance, by certain forms of vulgar Marxism—they also do not have a coherence and independence of the wider political and social world that would allow one to treat them completely in abstraction. One cannot, that is to say, sensibly expect to develop a cognitively illuminating *Logik der Weltbilder* (of the kind, for instance, envisaged at one point by Habermas)¹⁸ in which one maps their structure (and development) as purportedly freestanding abstract entities. They are a part of real history, like most of the rest of life.

Tasks of Political Theory

The image of the subject-matter of political philosophy that one finds when one puts together the three elements of the realist view sketched above is rather clear. In the historical period we can survey we find ourselves as finite, vulnerable, mutually dependent creatures who are also independent sources of action and judgment. We are bound to each other by various relations of power, and we try to act in a concerted way under pressure of time and resources, and in such a way as to give some kind of account to ourselves and others about why we are acting in the way we are; within limits, and unless we are preternaturally tolerant or insightful, we expect others to try to give us some kind of similar account of themselves and their actions. The account they give will almost certainly contain some appeal to particular facts about their social environment and historically specific concepts and theories, although they may well not recognise them as such—they may, for instance, think of them as Divine Laws or Obvious Facts or Self-Evident Dictates of Reason or Sheer Common Sense. With this picture in mind one can ask oneself what the task of political philosophy is. This means not only what it might ideally be capable of doing, but also what it in fact has done, how it has in fact informed the social world, and what role it has actually played in politics.

Understanding, Evaluation, Orientation

I would like to discuss this topic under five heads. First of all, one might think that political philosophy was a systematic attempt to understand how the organised forms of act-

ing together in a given society actually work, and to explain why certain decisions are taken, why certain projects fail and others succeed, or why social and political action exhibits the patterns it does. There might, to be sure, be disagreement about what exactly “understanding” was supposed to mean in the case of politics. Is the best we can aspire to a kind of low-level descriptive account of the various ways in which the political systems that we have encountered in the past or the present are actually organised, or can we get beyond this to formulate some generalisations about the types of systems that exist, or can we even find for the realm of politics something like the general laws that hold in the realm of nature, laws that will support counterfactuals and allow us to predict what will occur? Or is this model itself an inappropriate imitation of the study of nature, and is the understanding of politics we should wish to attain more like the understanding of a text or of another human being than like our understanding of the solar system or of the structure of the human body? Can one understand politics without understanding history, especially the history of political thought, and will this distinguish political philosophy from some other kinds of philosophy (such as, perhaps, logic) to which the study of history is not integral? However one might finally decide what the proper form (or forms) of understanding are, this general task does not seem in principle more problematic for political theory than for any of the other human sciences.

It is, however, also a reasonable generalisation about societies we know that the human beings who live in them are not merely cognitive beings, interested only or even primarily in understanding the world around us. Although Aristotle may have been right to claim that a desire to know

is part of the fundamental constitution of human nature, if one means by that the constitution of any human society we could easily recognise, Nietzsche is also correct to emphasise that the impulse to evaluate our surroundings, our fellows, and ourselves is at least as deeply rooted in our human nature as is any natural “desire to know.” “Der Mensch ist ein abschätzendes Tier.”¹⁹ We naturally compare one thing with another in the interests of finding out which one is “tastier,” “more pleasing to the eye,” “more useful,” and so forth. In this respect the study of politics is no different from most other human enterprises. We do not simply want to understand how the apartheid system worked in South Africa in the 1970s; we wish to judge it as being better or worse (in some respect) than other systems. There is no obvious *single* dimension along which we distinguish the good, the bad, the better, the worse, the best. One social system is more productive; another gives better subsidies to its symphony orchestras; a third has an especially perspicuous and flexible legal system. It is an assumption that there is always one single dimension for assessing persons and their actions that has canonical priority. This is the dimension of moral evaluation; “good/evil” is supposed always to trump any other form of evaluation, but that is an assumption, probably the result of the long history of the Christianisation and then gradual de-Christianisation of Europe, which one need not make. Evaluation need not mean moral evaluation, but might include assessments of efficiency (measured in one or another of varying ways), simplicity, perspicuousness, aesthetic appeal, and so on. It is natural for the modern inheritors of the Western tradition of religion and philosophy to think that we know what

the “proper” relation is between the desire to know and the desire to evaluate. We do not wish to “judge” or assess our surrounding merely as a kind of expressive activity carelessly projected onto the world, but we wish to evaluate the world “correctly,” i.e., in accordance with what it truly is, and the desire to know is directed at determining what the world truly is. Lenin specifically (and correctly) commends this line of thought when he states that revolutionary praxis requires revolutionary theory.²⁰

The third point I would like to make is that humans do not merely wish to understand and evaluate the world around them; it is often claimed that humans’ need for general orientation in action is at least as important as the wish for piecemeal understanding or assessment. This has generally been taken to mean one of several slightly different things. Nineteenth-century discussions often emphasise that people wish to lead a “meaningful” life, and then connect this with some kind of desire for a sense of locatedness or having a place in the world. There is then often a shift from this to the further idea that people need representation or a surveyable image of their place in the world. Sometimes this desire for orientation is construed as what is called a “metaphysical need,” and an attempt is made to argue that they need a world-picture or worldview, a theory or image of the world *as a whole*.²¹ A further sense in which I can speak of looking for an orientation is not connected with having a general picture or a sense of the meaningfulness of the world, but with having a clear and motivationally effective set of principles and directives about how to act in life, what to do, or perhaps about what goals I should pursue. People who do not know how they should act in a situa-

tion are more likely to experience frustration, confusion, or fear; Durkheim called this state *anomie*.²² To say that I have a sense of the locatedness of my life or that I have relatively clear principles and goals—I know what I think I “ought” to do—does not in itself necessarily imply that I can see my own life in a positive light. Slaves in the ancient world, one can assume, often had a clear sense of their “place”—we might think, too clear a sense of their place—and they rarely suffered from *anomie*, but this did not mean that they were able to see the life they were living as having positive value, or, to use a nineteenth-century expression, to “affirm themselves” in it. This final stage of the argument was, then, often a prelude to some kind of rehabilitation of monotheistic religion or of some philosophical *Weltanschauung* that was an analogue of such a religion. Monotheistic religions in the West have tended to conflate having a general orientation in life, having a specific theory of the world, having a sense of the positive meaningfulness of one’s existence, and having a fixed set of rules for behaviour, but these elements are in principle separable. As both Marx and Nietzsche pointed out, it is completely unclear why I can’t have a sense of my place in the world simply by being embedded and participating in its practices, *provided* these practices were sufficiently satisfactory, without having a single general representation of why it all makes sense. Marx in particular seemed to hold that having a sense of positive meaningfulness in one’s life was a question of acting and interacting, especially of participating in social, productive activities, rather than of having a theory of any kind. The “metaphysical need,” in any case, both Marx and Nietzsche held, is a historical phenomenon that arises under determinate circumstances, and could be

expected to disappear under other circumstances that we could relatively easily envisage.

Humans in modern societies are driven by a perhaps desperate hope that they might find some way of mobilising their theoretical and empirical knowledge and their evaluative systems so as both to locate themselves and their projects in some larger imaginative structure that makes sense to them, and to guide their actions to bring about what they would find to be satisfactory (or at any rate “less unsatisfactory”) outcomes or to improve in some other way the life they live. Furthermore, many modern agents would like it to be the case that the form of orientation which their life has is, if not “true,” at least compatible with the best available knowledge, and they would like the principles by which they guide their action to be in some kind of contact with reality, although anyone would be hard put to say precisely what was meant by that. Both the extent to which this hope is present in a certain group and the extent to which it can be realised are empirical matters, although one would have to be extremely sanguine to expect it to be realised to any significant extent.

Conceptual Innovation

The fourth task that political philosophy might perform is one of making a constructive contribution to politics by conceptual invention or innovation. Political agents can face a variety of different kinds of problematic situation. Let me start with two cases. Sometimes people think they know rather clearly what immediate goals they wish to attain, and also know what powers, means, or resources would have to

be at their disposal if they were to have a chance of attaining the goals. Thus a political party might know they would like to enact a certain piece of legislation and also know they need a certain number of votes from members of one of the opposition parties to carry the legislation; the problem is how to get them. One might think that what the party needs here is what some have called “technical” or “instrumental” knowledge. Of course, from the fact that one might say they “need” this knowledge, it does not follow that any such knowledge in fact exists, any more than it follows from the fact that I say a man in the desert needs water that any water is at all potentially available to him. A second possible case is one in which the members of some group do not know which of a number of pre-given proposals is best, either best for their immediate or long-term interests, or “best” in some other sense. Here one might naturally be inclined to say that they need help in assessing the given options.

In addition to these two kinds of case, however, there are also indeterminately many other kinds of problematic situation, and many of them are difficult to discuss because the problem itself is often not clearly visible as a problem until one has the answer or a possible set of answers. People, that is, can be at a loss what to do or fail to know what they want because they are confused about what is wrong or what the problem precisely is. They do not understand the situation in which they find themselves, and so don’t even know what they should be looking for. In such cases, it is sometimes possible that a certain kind of conceptual innovation may help them. Political theory might (in some cases) discharge the function of providing a new thought-instrument or conceptual tool to help particular people understand and define,

and thus begin to deal with, certain problems. The archetyp-
ical case I have in mind here is the early modern invention
of the concept of “the state” as an abstract structure of power
and authority distinct both from the population and from
the prince, aristocracy, or ruling class, which successfully
enforces a monopoly of legitimate violence within a certain
territory.²³ Proposing to think about politics through em-
ploying the concept of “the state” in a central place in one’s
theory is not like offering a solution to the difficulties that
confronted the agents in the two initial examples discussed
above.

“Conceptual innovation” in the sense intended is not
much like simply introducing a new lexical item into speech
to designate something that already exists, as when people
decided to call a certain illness that was afflicting the popu-
lation “bubonic plague,” or, for that matter, it is not like giv-
ing a simple name to something that does not (yet) exist,
as when Mr. Biro, the inventor of the ballpoint pen, might
have sat down to try to invent a writing instrument that he
proposed to name after himself. In interesting cases, like
“the state,” introducing the “concept” requires one to get
people not merely to use a certain word, but also to enter-
tain a certain kind of theory, which has a strong “normative”
component. You don’t “have” the concept of the state unless
you have the idea of a freestanding form of *authority*. and
the idea of authority requires some appeal to notions like
“ought” or “should.” You do not automatically have a state
when some group of people *in fact* completely controls the
use of violence within a territory—if you did, every group
of successful kidnappers would constitute a “state.” Rather,
a state exists only if enough people think they “ought” to

obey the orders of some person or designated group of people, in the right sense of “ought.” The sense of “ought” in question might be indeterminate in certain ways, but it must certainly go beyond the sense of “ought” implicit in saying, “You ought to do what he says,” meaning that since he is holding a gun to your head, it would be exceedingly inadvisable to fail to do what he requests. Characteristically, the concept “the state” is introduced *together with* a theory about the nature and the source of the authority which the abstract entity that is so named is supposed to have. In the early modern period this was usually some version of the social contract theory. Of course, once the state actually gets established as a distinct and massive social reality that cannot be ignored, one can come to reflect that the purported sources of its “authority” are deficient, that the social contract theory is invalid, false, or confused, and one might even come to the conclusion that the state “ought” to have no real authority. To say this retrospectively, that is, to call an entity that was in some sense originally introduced by being *defined* as a locus of authority “nonauthoritative,” is, under the circumstances, no more problematic than continuing to call Greenland “Greenland” even after one discovers that it is not, after all—or, at any rate, was not until the recent acceleration of global warming—very green.

When they were introduced, concepts like “the state” did not exactly mirror any fully preexisting reality, because using these concepts represented as much an aspiration as a description. It is also the case that merely *using* the concepts did not *by itself*, without the assistance of real social forces that actually act in history, bring any state into existence; neither concepts nor theories realise themselves. Nevertheless

inventing this new concept, in this case by transforming the meaning of existing terms such as *status/estat/stato*, could be an important contribution both to clarifying an obscure situation and to guiding action directed at institutional change. Having the “concept” (in the requisite sense, including the various theory-fragments that were associated with it) meant that one saw certain problems clearly, namely, the problems of ensuring political order in an incipiently atomised society without recourse to religion, and it also meant that one had a solution, or at any rate a suggestion for a solution that one could try to put to work. Having the concept of “the state” could give one, then, an important analytic tool that could allow one to think more clearly about social processes in train, and could help one to see what actions are required.

Sometimes conceptual innovations work, take hold, and flourish in the world, the mind, and the imagination. Vivid examples of this include “the state” and “democracy” (a term originally coined sometime in the mists of the sixth century BC, which was politically active for a couple of centuries, and was then put away on the shelf for two thousand years to be resurrected and redefined out of all recognition in the early twentieth century).²⁴ When such innovations work, they imprint themselves on the world. “The state” is now not merely a concept but a social reality. If Nietzsche’s account in *Zur Genealogie der Moral* is at all correct, the concept of “evil” is a similar kind of conceptual innovation that has put down roots and created a psychic, and somatic, reality to which it now refers. Sometimes, to be sure, innovative conceptual constructs do not work (as in the case of *phalanstère*, *Führerprinzip*, “the Third Way,” or “the dictatorship of the proletariat”). Conceptual innovation in the sense in question here is a complicated

process in which descriptive, analytic, normative, and aspirational elements are intricately intertwined. What it means in each case to say that a particular conceptual proposal did not work is, thus, a complicated question to which, probably, only a detailed historically specific answer can be given. Sometimes the failure seems to result directly from the cognitive deficiencies of the proposed innovation: the Third Way had no content and was useless as an analytic or cognitive tool, so it was swiftly seen to be a mere exercise in attaching a brand-label to various disparate policies developed by the first New Labour government, and the use of the term was abandoned. Sometimes the proposal wasn't sufficiently attractive or plausible to enough people for it to be given a real chance, such as in the case of the *phalanstères*. Sometimes the cause of failure is not clear. Did the *Führerprinzip* fail because it was analytically or cognitively deficient, because too many humans could not tolerate the consequences of accepting it, or because of the military defeat of the Third Reich? Or because of some combination of all three?

To repeat, having the *idea* of the state does not automatically ensure that one has a proper, full understanding of what having a state would or does imply, nor, as has already been mentioned, does it ensure that a state really exists. The reason is clear: for there to be a state there must exist an actual concentration of power of a certain kind that does not always exist, and probably could not exist in certain historical periods. Equally, however, because a state is a conjunction of concentrated power and a certain kind of abstract authority, there is a sense in which one could not “really” have *the state*, unless one had a minimally proper and not completely deviant concept of it. “State authority” is not the

kind of thing that can exist independently of some form of conceptualisation.

The references above to conceptual tools might suggest that one should think of this as a kind of “pragmatic” task for political philosophy, but there are some important differences between the paradigmatic cases I have in mind here and everyday cases of “pragmatic” problem solving. First, in everyday cases one usually knows what the problem is before looking for the solution, as in the two cases described at the very start of this section. In many of the cases of conceptual innovation that I have in mind, creating the conceptual tools is a precondition to coming to a clear understanding of what the problem was in the first place. It is very difficult to describe the transition after it has taken place because it is difficult for us to put ourselves back into the situation of confusion, indeterminacy, and perplexity that existed before the new “tool” brought clarity, and this means it is difficult for us to retain a vivid sense of what a difference having the concept made. We can just barely imagine ourselves in a world in which there are no states, as opposed to local barons, warlords, clans, primitive communal forms of village organisation, etc. Some forms of Kantianism put great weight on “what we can imagine,” holding that this can be a source of insight into necessary connections. Thus various of Kant’s arguments about space and time depend on the purported fact that it is impossible for us to imagine certain things: we can know, Kant claims, a priori that space has only three dimensions because we cannot imagine it as having more than three dimensions. History in the form of non-Euclidean geometry and modern physics has put paid to that particular line of argument, but in general we should

beware of depending too much on “what we can imagine,” especially in politics. As Nietzsche puts it somewhere, sometimes the fact that you can’t imagine a situation in which things are very different from the way they are now is not an especially good argument for the claim that they *must* be as they now are, but, rather, represents a failure of your powers about which you should feel mildly apologetic. Sometimes the right response to “But I can’t *imagine* that” is “Oh yes, you can. Please just try harder”; sometimes the right response is “Yes, I see that you can’t, poor thing, perhaps we can get you some help.”

There is a second difference between conceptual innovation and the pragmatic invention of tools. When we use a tool in everyday life, it usually remains a detached instrument under my control and activated only when, where, and how I decide. I tie some catnip to the end of a broom handle to lure Tabitha down off the roof, but when that episode is finished, I either decompose the new tool (the “capture”) completely or put it away under the stairs: Tabitha is off the roof; nothing else has changed. Given the extremely rudimentary nature of her general mental processes and the weakness of her memory, it is not even guaranteed that she won’t find herself back up in the same place on the roof again tomorrow, mewling piteously in the same way as today. In contrast, conceptual innovations often “stick,” escape our control and become part of reality itself. Once Hobbes invents the idea of the “state,” this idea can come into contact with real social forces with unforeseeable results. The “tool” develops a life of its own, and can become an inextricable part of the fabric of life itself.²⁵ “The state” might be a conceptual innovation invented to deal with a certain real prob-

lem (that of demonstrating how to ensure self-preservation and an order of a certain kind), but regardless of Hobbes's own views, it quickly attracts to itself independent loyalty, so that in the end people are willing to sacrifice their lives for it. Often you can't see the original problem clearly until you have the conceptual instrument, but having the instrument can then change the "real" situation with which one is confronted so that other, unforeseen problems emerge.

Ideology

The fifth possible function of political theory is more controversial. Many theorists have held that political theories have had the further function of either propounding and fostering, or that they ought to have the function of analysing and helping to dissolve, ideologies.²⁶ If the earlier discussion is correct, power in its various forms is an important feature of human societies. When we think of power, we most naturally and immediately think of relatively direct ways in which it is employed. An adult has the power to pick up a package that weighs one kilo; a national government exercises its power by locking up those who break the law; a large firm that is struggling with a number of competitors to increase its market share uses its financial power to buy out and eliminate one or two of these competitors. One characteristic of the use of power here, a characteristic that makes it rather easy to identify the exercise of power, is that it is being used to overcome some kind of distinct visible resistance: the weight of the package, the attempts on the part of lawbreakers to evade or escape the attentions of the police, the various actions of the competing firms before they are

eliminated. Power, however, can also be used indirectly to shape opinions, attitudes, and desires, and thus to manufacture what looks like “consent,” and in this form, many have wanted to claim, it is not so easily visible. Thus the arms industry can use its financial power to influence newspapers in the direction of generating a climate of fear that will be conducive to higher governmental expenditures on weapons, or oil companies can fund research directed at demonstrating that global warming is not caused by the burning of fossil fuels. In a society in which powerful social agencies have a strong interest in commercializing as many aspects of human life as possible and have succeeded to a considerable extent in implementing this interest, it would not be surprising if people came to think that the existence of a “free market” in health care, education, organ transplanting, or the adoption of children was “natural” and required no further comment, scrutiny, or explanation. This belief would be a reflection of how things appeared to be (in their society). Such effects of power can be less visible because they operate on amorphous initial states rather than against distinctly constituted opposition; after all, who “initially” would have any view whatever about the connection between global warming and fossil fuels? People will also be unlikely to have very well-formed beliefs about how organ transplants are organized until the society comes to have a technological way of performing such transplants. How exactly power relations operate to generate or influence the formation of beliefs, desires, and attitudes is a complex question, and there will probably be little of much significance one will be able to say in general about the mechanisms by which this influence is exercised. Only a historical account of the particular details

of the case will be at all enlightening. In some central and important cases, however, so the proponents of the theory of “ideology” argue, the existence of specific power relations in the society will produce an appearance of a particular kind. Certain features of the society that are merely local and contingent, and maintained in existence only by the continual exercise of power, will come to seem as if they were universal, necessary, invariant, or natural features of all forms of human social life, or as if they arose spontaneously and uncoercedly by free human action. A “free market” requires constant intervention by powerful social agencies if it is to maintain itself in existence, but in a society in which that constant intervention has been overwhelmingly successful and its forms traditional, people’s basic beliefs and desires will have become channeled²⁷ so that the “market” comes to seem natural. If this happens, then agents who have a particular interest in the maintenance of the market (e.g., companies that profit by providing private health services) will be in a position to present what are in fact merely their particular interests as universal interests.

An ideology, then, is a set of beliefs, attitudes, preferences that are distorted as a result of the operation of specific relations of power; the distortion will characteristically take the form of presenting these beliefs, desires, etc., as inherently connected with some universal interest, when in fact they are subservient to particular interests. One can think of an ideology as a composite comprising three elements:

1. a certain configuration of power;
2. this configuration of power brings it about that certain contingent, variable features of our human mode of ex-

istence (which are in fact maintained in existence only by the constant exercise of that power) appear to be universal, “natural,” or necessary or spontaneously arising features;

3. as a result of (2), certain particular interests can plausibly present themselves as universal ones.

If ideologies exist, that is, if the term has any real use at all, then it would seem that a political theory or political philosophy could be related to a given ideology in at least two distinct ways. One possibility would be that a political philosophy could play a progressive role in combating ideological illusion, such as when the philosophy in question demonstrates the dependence of certain beliefs or desires on the continued existence of particular configurations of power that would otherwise remain hidden. This is philosophy as “criticism of ideology.” A second possibility is that a political theory or philosophy itself played an ideological role in society in that it fostered certain common ideological illusions, made them more difficult to detect, or created new ones, e.g., the idea that New Labour could represent a Third Way, or that all people in every society everywhere aspire before all else to a particular kind of “democratic” political culture. The ideological role can be relatively active or relatively passive; that is, a political theory can actively promote a certain conceptual confusion or an ideological appearance, or, negatively, it can divert attention away from the dependency of some form of consciousness on a particular configuration of power. A political theory can in principle divert attention from the distorting influence of relations of power without its even being the case that some part of the

content of the theory, narrowly construed, is false, wrong, or incorrect. Diverting attention from the way in which certain beliefs, desires, attitudes, or values are the result of particular power relations, then, can be a sophisticated way of contributing to the maintenance of an ideology, and one that will be relatively immune to normal forms of empirical refutation. If I claim (falsely) that all human societies, or all human societies at a certain level of economic development, have a free market in health services, that is a claim that can be demonstrated to be false. On the other hand, if I focus your attention in a very intense way on the various different tariffs and pricing schema that doctors or hospitals or drug companies impose for their products and services, and if I become morally outraged by “excessive” costs some drug companies charge, discussing at great length the relative rates of profit in different sectors of the economy, and pressing the moral claims of patients, it is not at all obvious that anything I say may be straightforwardly “false”; after all, who knows what “excessive” means? However, by proceeding in this way I might well focus your attention on narrow issues of “just” pricing, turning it away from more pressing issues about the acceptance in some societies of the very existence of a free market for drugs and medical services. One can even argue that the *more* outraged I become about the excessive price, the more I obscure the underlying issue. One way, then, in which a political philosophy can be ideological is by presenting a relatively marginal issue as if it were central and essential. The (mis)direction of limited human attention in this case would be the analogue in the theoretical sphere of the Nietzschean issues of “priority” discussed above.

If ideologies exist, it does not seem outrageous to assume that analyzing and criticizing them is a reputable task for a political theory. This scheme of five possible tasks that emerges, then, is rather crude, and to be completely convincing it would have to be elaborated and qualified in various ways. In particular understanding, evaluation, and guidance are complexly connected in ways one would have to discuss. However, as a first approximation we will assume that all five of these goals or functions for political philosophy are unobjectionable.